Balance and Voiding (v1.2.0)[1]

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This document is an elaboration on materials and principles taught over the course of several classes at *Klingenspiel* in Vienna. The focus of these lessons were on ways of actively using balance to prepare and initiate actions, especially voids. To make that possible, however, a fencer must be able to control and manipulate their balance, both in the guard and in transitory and preparatory positions. For many fencers, however, balance is something they try to retain (to 'keep one's balance'), not something they actively use. To remedy that, the first section of this document contains drills and exercises aimed at developing an awareness of balance in various positions and movements. It also contains descriptions of how I manipulate my balance to initiate various common pieces of footwork. The second section combines these movements into simple solo- and partner drills. The third and final section contains partner drills that gradually build from simple action/reaction to something resembling constrained sparring.

1. Fundamentals

The human body has two centres of balance. One, the head, is gimballed, the other, the 'centre of gravity', is located somewhere around the navel; moving either causes the rest of the body to follow. It can be helpful to think of the rapier as a third centre of balance. It is not as potent as the other two, but especially a heavier rapier can significantly alter one's balance. For the purposes of this chapter then, one can think of 'balance' as the equilibrium between the two centres, the rapier, and whatever is counteracting gravity—usually one or both feet. The distance and orientation of your feet, your 'base', is another important factor. Standing on both feet, set roughly shoulder-width apart provides a stable platform, standing on the toes of a single foot does not. As we shall see, however, stability is not always desirable, and neither is a broad, stable base.

The first step toward intentionally manipulating one's balance is to become sensitive to it. Therefore, before working on any of the material below—preferably before reading any further—take your rapier and move as you usually would, observing your balance as you do so. As you work through the rest of this chapter, endeavour to come back to this awareness; it is the basis for everything below.

Guard

While this chapter is agnostic to the style of your guard, but there are a some things that I have

[1] This document is part of a collection of texts on Italian rapier fencing, and may reference parts that are not included here. The current version of the full collection can be found on https://github.com/laugedideriksen/ItalianRapier.

found helpful:[2]

- Place the majority of your weight on the balls of your feet. This does not mean lifting your heels of the floor, however!
- While in your guard, slowly move your one or both of your centres of balance in a direction until you cross the point where you can no longer stay in place and have to catch yourself.
- Practice moving right up to that 'point of no return' and stay there.
- Change a small detail—the angle of your back foot, the distance between your feet ('North/South' and or 'East/West'), or the angle of your upper body—and observe how that changes any of the above.

When working through the rest of this chapter, periodically come back to the guard and see if anything needs altering.

Drop step

The drop step is used across martial arts, but I became aware of it through the work of Rory Miller. In essence, a drop step in an intentional free fall. One can think of it as lifting one foot off the ground without first taking one's weight off of it, and the catching oneself before hitting the ground. The human body is pretty good at keeping itself from landing face-first on the floor, and so it can help to focus on removing the leg swiftly, and let the catching take care of itself. For a detailed description, see Rory Miller's blog post on the topic.[3]

Altered drop step

A limitation of the drop step is that it always results in a movement along the line between one's feet. By shifting one's weight or leaning in the direction wants to 'fall', however, it is possible to alter that trajectory, at the cost of telegraphing one's intention. When practising this, start by clearly separating the two stages of the movement: first shift weight and/or lean, then perform a drop step. Experiment with different amounts of leaning and shifting, from barely noticeable to falling over —both ends of that spectrum can be very useful.

Lunge

What I have described as an altered drop step above, is almost identical to the footwork of a rapier lunge.[4] All that is missing, is to add the upper-body parts of the lunge (extending the arm, turning the torso, getting behind the hilt, etc.). A few things to keep in mind:

- the order of movement is: extend arm–lean/shift–drop step–catch–recover or advance. Always extend the arm first!

[2] For a thorough discussion of rapier guards, see *Finding the Guard* in the full collection, as well as *Cues and Details* in the full collection.

[3] As Miller point out, it is also possible to drop straight down by 'lifting' both feet at the same time. This is not very idiomatic to Italian rapier fencing at all, but can nonetheless catch an opponent by surprise.

[4] Or at least the way I teach it. The proverbial cat is making itself scarce again.

- at no point during the lunge should one push off of the back foot.[5]

Once that begins to feel smooth, find the 'point of no return'—the point beyond which one has to commit to the drop step. Then practice getting to that point as quickly as possible, without kipping over into a full lunge. That point, and being able to explosively get to it, goes a long way towards feinting convincingly (see also *Cues and Details* in the full collection).

Traverso Weapon Side

A traverso, from the word for 'going across', is mechanically similar to a lunge, but instead of forwards, one moves diagonally or sidewards. When 'traversing' to the weapon side, it is often easiest to go diagonally forward, as that is closest to the strong line. One thing to note about a traverso to the weapon side is that it brings the blade off-line. While this does create an opening—which can be addressed with the empty hand—it also allows one to attack from different angles.

Traverso Empty-hand side

For the same reason that a traverso to the weapon side tends to move diagonally forward, a traverso to the empty-hand side tends to move diagonally backward. Contrary to a traverso to the weapon side, it is possible to leave the rapier on-line; one can think of leaving the blade in place and moving the body around it.

Passata Sotto

Shift weight back, then drop step The passata sotto is quite an athletic movement and an excellent way to pull one's groin if one is not used to it.

[5] This assumes that one leaves the back foot in place during the lunge, which I firmly believe is the correct thing to do.



Figure 1: Plate 16 (cropped) from Philibert de la Touche's *Les Vrais Principes de l'Espée Seule* (1670). The figure on the right has performed a passata sotto.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/4/47/Les_Vrays_principes_de_l%27esp%C3%A9e_Seule_La_Touche_Planche16.jpeg

The basic order of movement remains the same: extend arm–shift/lean–quasi drop step. The trick is to shift the weight backwards while leaning (bending at the hip) forwards.

Backwards lunge

The backwards lunge is a rare movement, and that for a reason. But it is a workable alternative for anyone unable to do a passata sotto. The mechanics are the same as a lunge, with two significant differences: both point and head are facing away from the direction of travel. The resulting order of movement is: extend arm (forward)–lean/shift (backwards)–drop step (backwards)–recover(forwards) or retreat (backwards).

This may initially seem a little schizophrenic, which also makes it a good exercise

Incartata (Volte)

Incartata (or volte) and scanzo are often spoken about as alternatives to one another. In many cases they are, but they differ significant in the details.

Scanzo

Shift weight, then 'throw' shoulder.

Gathering Step

Different ways of finishing—as a regular step, or any of the movements above.

Passata

As lunge + trav L.

2. Simple Drills

TK. These drills work regardless of whether both fencers hold their weapon in the same hand or not.

On Cue

This drill is a simplified version of classic *salle* footwork and should be done with weapons. The instructor is limited to four signs: lunge, traverso left, incartata, and passata sotto. The goal is to help the students find a guard that lets them move in all directions.

On Cue with Gathering Step

As the drill above, but the instructor can also signal a gathering step forward or backward (see 'Gathering Step' above). For the purposes of this drill, I use the regular signals for 'step forwards' and 'step backwards'.

On Cue with Free Steps

As 'On Cue' above, but instead of standing still, the students move freely backwards and forwards. The goal is to train changes of direction, and retaining control of one's balance while in motion.

Stick I

Partner drill. Both partners place the palm of the weapon hand against opposite ends of a dowel or broomstick. One leads, the other follows using lunges, traversi left, incartata, and back lunges. The goal is to not drop the stick. A certain amount of pressure on the stick helps you feel what your partner is doing.

Stick II

Same as above, but adding steps forwards and backwards.

Stick III

Same as Stick II, but there is no designated leader and follower. Think of it as both partners following, not both partners leading.

Bind I–III

The same as Stick I–III, but using rapiers in the bind. Once this works, add disengages.

Voiding

Partner drill. A stands in their guard, B attacks with a thrust in opposition on the inside or the outside. If the attack is on the inside, A voids with a incartata or scanzo; if the attack is on the outside, A voids with a traverso left. In both cases, A 'leaves' their blade in the middle as described above.

Voiding in Motion

As above, but A is freely stepping backwards and forwards. B keeps the distance until they attack.

3. Complex Drills

Each of the following drills is made up of a series of steps and are designed to be practised progressively—first step one, once that works at full speed, step one and two, then one and two and three, etc. Start each iteration slower than you think and speed it up to something like sparring speed over 4–8 repetitions.

The goal of each action is to hit the opponent while not getting hit, but it is not the goal of the drill to win at all costs. Each action should counter the previous action, but especially as speed and intensity increase, not every action will be successful. That is fine. Analyse what went wrong and try again. As with the simple drills, focus on balance and on using it to initiate each action.

These drills encourages a style of fencing that emphasises control over explosiveness. Control does not mean strength, however. A weaker fencer with good structure and good technique (strong on weak, etc.) has little issue controlling a much stronger fencer. Nonetheless, fencers who have based their style on being faster than their opponents may find it frustrating.

3.1. First Drill

Fencers (A and B) start in middle distance (where either can hit the other with a lunge).

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside; B disengages; A rebinds. On a disengage of their choice, A lunges, striking B with a thrust in opposition instead of rebinding.

1. If A attacks on the inside, B voids with a volte or scanzo; if A attacks on the outside, B voids with a traverso L. In either case, B 'leaves' their blade in the middle line, as described in section 1 above.

1. A parries B's blade with their empty hand, and strikes B with a stramazone to the head. The stramazone can be done with or without a step of the back foot.

3.2. Second Drill

Fencers start at a distance where either can strike the other with a gathering step and a lunge.

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside with a gathering step; B disengages and lunges, striking A with a thrust in opposition.
2. If B attacks on the inside, A voids with a volte or scanzo; if B attacks on the outside, A voids with a traverso L. In either case, A 'leaves' their blade in the middle line, as described in section 1 above.
3. As 2 above, but instead of disengaging and striking, B may instead take a step backwards. If they do, A finishes the gathering step as a step forward, effectively resetting the situation.
4. As 3 above, but from the initial position, either fencer may initiate the action with a gathering step. At this point, this drill begins to resemble a constrained for of sparring, and the intensity should eventually reflect that.

3.3. Third Drill

This drill combines elements of the two drills above. Fencers start at a distance where either can strike the other with a gathering step and a lunge.

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside with a gathering step; B disengages and lunges, striking A with a thrust in opposition.
2. A either takes B's disengage as a tempo to strike them with a thrust in opposition,1 or voids B's attack with a volte/scanzo or traverso L, depending on whether B attacks on the inside or the outside.
3. If A attacks into B's disengage, B voids A's attack with a volte/scanzo or traverso L.
4. If B voids, A parries B's blade with their empty hand, and strikes B with a stramazone to the head. The stramazone can be done with or without a step of the back foot. If A voids, B parries with the empty hand, etc.
5. Instead of disengaging and striking when a seeks the bind, B may take a step backwards. If they do, A finishes the gathering step as a step forward, effectively resetting the situation.
6. As 5 above, but from the initial position, either fencer may initiate the action by seeking the bind with a gathering step. Adding this step makes for an extremely complex drill and in most cases it is best left out.

3.4. Improvising Drills

Once two fencers have repertoire of actions and are comfortable moving within the idiom of their style (whether that is as broad as 'seventeenth-century Italian rapier' or as narrow as 'Rapier after Capo Ferro'), they can begin to improvise drills like the ones above. Doing so is a great awareness drill, and can be tailored to reinforce a fencer's strength or to address their weaknesses. Drills like these can also given a focus other than balance, e.g. moving off line, using the empty hand, blade-foot coordination, etc. I have found the following guidelines to be helpful:

- Agree on a starting distance and action, e.g. a beat and a thrust, seeking a bind, etc. The drills above are ambidextrous and symmetrical, but that is not a requirement.
- Each iteration of the drill should be done slowly and then sped up over 4–8 repetitions.
- Regardless of the speed, every action should be done with full force aiming at good targets.
- Try to keep each 'turn' to one or, at most, two actions each.
- Each action after the first should be what Rory Miller calls a golden move (Miller 2016): it protects you, hurts your opponent, puts you in a better position, puts your opponent in a worse position.
- Keep the exchanges relatively short (2–5 'turns' at most), otherwise what started as a fencing drill becomes a memory game.

References

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